

Chapter 82-1

Among the four children of the Liang family, Liang Xinzhou was the most steady and composed.

He was the eldest son and had learned the most things since childhood. After the family had younger siblings, the attention on him wasn't as high anymore, but he would take the initiative to help look after his younger brother and sisters.

Liang Xinhe had a lively personality but was kind-hearted, and had been mischievous since he was young.

As for Liang Wanwan, no one knew who she took after—she had been introverted since childhood, didn't like to talk much, and always liked sitting in her room drawing or gazing at the sky alone.

When the nanny took her outside, she would just sit on the lawn pulling grass.

As for Liang Shi, there was no need to mention her—she had been rebellious since her teenage years, and it was only recently that there were signs of improvement.

It was also possible that she had changed because she found out she wasn't the Liang family's biological child.

Liang Xinzhou was only three years older than Liang Xinhe, so they could be considered to have grown up together, with a sense of companionship in their growth.

But Liang Shi was different.

When Liang Shi was born, Liang Xinzhou was already sensible. Father Liang was perpetually busy with work matters, and Qiu Zimin would occasionally be lazy and not pay much attention to this child.

So it was often Liang Xinzhou who helped take care of her.

It could be said that Liang Shi was practically raised single-handedly by Liang Xinzhou.

Aside from regular school days when Liang Xinzhou wasn't home, on rest days, apart from attending his extracurricular classes, Liang Xinzhou would play with Liang Shi.

Liang Shi was also sensible when she was little—like a tiny little bean, with her hair in princess braids, wearing a floral dress, toddling unsteadily behind Liang Xinzhou, calling out in a milky voice: "Big brother, gege¹."

By the time Liang Wanwan was born, Liang Xinzhou was already in high school and didn't have as much time to look after children.

So he wasn't that close to Liang Wanwan.

Liang Xinhe was alright though—he had always been carefree, and to him, both sisters were the same; he doted on them both.

He had never favored one over the other.

It was probably the experience of having younger siblings who were all quite a handful that made Liang Xinzhou mature early—he had almost never had a rebellious phase.

He arranged clearly what should be done at each stage and lived his life step by step.

Going to school, graduating, joining the company, getting married—except for being a step late in having children.

Everything else could be called a template life.

So he had never been hit at home.

Liang Xinhe was naughty when he was young, often playing with a bunch of delinquents and even gambling with people. After Qiu Zimin found out, she brought him back, and the couple administered a combined education.

Liang Xinhe was beaten quite badly.

Liang Xinzhou was different—he had never done anything out of line. When choosing his major for the gaokao², he scored very high marks, then discussed with his family which university to attend, became an exchange student during his undergraduate years, and applied to study abroad for graduate school—he was always the one who made his family most satisfied.

Yet in just half a month, Liang Xinzhou had been hit twice because of this matter.

And it was slaps to the face.

His roar had startled everyone, even making Liang Wanwan, who was sitting on the sofa, shiver.

Liang Xinhe said timidly: "Big brother..."

He wanted to mediate but didn't know where to start.

Liang Xinzhou took a deep breath. "This place was originally yours, so we'll move out."

"Liang Xinzhou!" Qiu Zimin shouted. "What did you say?"

Liang Xinzhou threw off her arm. "I said we're moving out. You can live with whoever you want."

"Also." Liang Xinzhou pulled Yu Wan and was about to turn and leave, but stopped halfway, paused, and then said: "Don't say things like having no right to speak. Yu Wan married me, so she has the right to speak equally with everyone in this family. The most basic thing you taught me—have you forgotten respect between people?"

After saying this, he pulled Yu Wan upstairs. Only then did Father Liang step forward to stop this farce. "What are you all doing? Do you want to turn this family upside down?"

"Liang Xinzhou, what do you mean?" Father Liang said. "Can't you be quiet tonight? Do you have to stir up trouble?"

"What I told you back then, you didn't take a single word to heart." Liang Xinzhou sneered coldly, his icy gaze sweeping toward Guo Xinran. Guo Xinran immediately lowered her head.

Liang Xinzhou said coldly: "Then you all can just carry on. I don't want to put on a fake smile in this family. I'm exhausted from work every day, and I don't want to come home only to face this kind of meaningless socializing. Morality is for restraining oneself, not for preaching to others."

After that, he pulled Yu Wan upstairs to pack their things and left the old residence that very night.

Liang Xinhe even tried to stop them at the door, but Liang Xinzhou nearly ran him over with his car.

Even though Liang Xinhe was blocking the doorway, Liang Xinzhou still stepped on the gas and charged forward. If Liang Xinhe hadn't run fast, he probably really would have been done for.

Then he suddenly realized that big brother's anger before couldn't even be called anger—at most, it was just intimidation.

This time, he was truly angry. His expression was so dark it could condense into ink.

After leaving the Liang family's old residence, neither Liang Xinzhou's nor Yu Wan's phones could be reached—they didn't answer calls or reply to messages. The two were completely out of contact.

At three in the morning, Liang Xinhe tried to contact Liang Xinzhou but couldn't reach him.

Shortly after the two left the old residence, Qiu Zimin was so angered from arguing with Liang Xinzhou that she cried until she fainted. She was sent to the hospital for examination and was on an IV drip until morning before she woke up.

Liang Xinhe stayed at the hospital all night. In the morning, he rushed home to take a quick shower and then came to the company to catch big brother, thinking he would apologize or something. But Liang Xinzhou had directly thrown in the towel.

He didn't even come to the company.

Liang Xinhe urgently handled documents all morning, feeling extremely frustrated. At noon, he went downstairs to get some fresh air and bought a cup of coffee while he was at it.

When he came back, he happened to run into Liang Shi.

¹ **Gege (哥哥)**: Chinese term for "older brother." The repetition of "Big brother, gege" shows the child speaking in an endearing, childish manner, using both the formal term and the more affectionate form.

² **Gaokao (高考)**: The National College Entrance Examination in China, a standardized test that is the sole criterion for admission to almost all higher education institutions in mainland China. It is extremely competitive and is considered one of the most important events in a Chinese student's life.

Chapter 82-2

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Liang Xinhe vividly described last night's "bloodbath" at the Liang family.

Liang Shi listened as if she were hearing a story, and could even feel the intensity of last night through his words.

It really was quite a spectacular drama.

After Liang Xinhe finished speaking, he nestled into his chair and rubbed his face, sighing: "Do you think our family didn't pray to the gods this year? Why is our fate so troubled?"

Liang Shi: "....."

She answered righteously: "Feudal superstition is inadvisable."

Liang Xinhe: "?"

Liang Xinhe said helplessly: "You're the only one who can contact big brother. Send him a message and ask if he can come to work? The documents are piling up like a mountain. He has three meetings today, and I really can't handle it. My brain is about to rust. There's also a pile of crap going on at home, and I can't even focus during meetings."

Liang Shi obediently sent a message to Liang Xinzhou, asking if he was coming to work or not.

Liang Xinzhou replied concisely: [Not coming.]

Liang Shi showed the text to Liang Xinhe, indicating that she was innocent.

But while Liang Xinhe was looking, Liang Xinzhou sent another message: [No need to talk to your second brother. Just don't get involved in these matters.]

Liang Xinhe: "?"

He asked Liang Shi with a dejected expression: "Did I do something wrong? Is big brother targeting me?"

Liang Shi shook her head: "I don't know."

After a moment, looking at Liang Xinhe's expression as if he had lost his parents¹, she couldn't help but remind him: "Big brother just doesn't like you being a fence-sitter²."

"Me?" Liang Xinhe pointed at his own nose, looking incredulous. "I'm being a fence-sitter? Then what else should I do? Should I argue with Mom like he did, then also move out and just abandon the company? What would the Liang family become? Losing our managers in a single day—if word got out, wouldn't people laugh themselves to death?"

"So you think you're better than big brother at playing business mind games?" Liang Shi retorted.

Liang Xinhe was stunned, then shook his head: "That's impossible. I could never outplay big brother in my entire life."

Liang Xinhe was very self-aware.

If you ranked people's talent in business on a scale of 1-10, if Liang Xinzhou was at 7, Liang Xinhe could only be at 3.

Dongheng Group was also steadily rising under Liang Xinzhou's management. In an environment where the market was constantly being squeezed, Liang Xinzhou was doing better than Father Liang had.

So Liang Xinhe greatly admired his big brother.

But this time, Liang Xinhe felt that his big brother was going against everyone at home because he was biased.

After Liang Xinhe finished speaking, Liang Shi stared straight at him.

"You're still my little sister." Liang Xinhe immediately tried to remedy the situation. "I just think everyone's an adult now. Her coming back is just about dividing some family property. At most, everyone takes a little less and gives her a share. We don't usually keep in touch much anyway—just having a meal together during New Year and holidays would be fine. There's no need to make things so awkward. After all, we're all family."

"Look at you—didn't you used to run around everywhere too, almost never home? Now isn't that different from before." Liang Xinhe sighed. "I don't know why big brother is being so stubborn about this."

Liang Shi stared at him, still not speaking.

Liang Xinhe curled his fingers and knocked on the table. "If you have something to say, just say it. Don't play that game big brother plays with me. Also, I'm telling you all this because I consider you my real little sister—real! I don't think that person coming back can compare to you. It's mainly to make Mom and Dad happy. They're getting old, and having the family argue all day—what kind of image is that?"

"I know." Liang Shi said. "I wasn't thinking anything else either."

"Then why do you keep looking at me like that? What do you mean?" Liang Xinhe asked.

Liang Shi thought for a moment, then said in a low voice: "Do you think big brother would possibly bring shame to the Liang family?"

Liang Xinhe immediately denied it: "Impossible."

"So why don't you trust big brother?" Liang Shi said. "Big brother does everything flawlessly. So why would he suddenly act abnormally in this matter? You should think about it too."

Liang Xinhe: "....."

Inexplicably, he felt like he was being lectured.

"Big brother thinks that once that person comes back, there won't be a place for you in the family." Liang Xinhe said. "But you're still our little sister. That hasn't changed."

"That's not important." Liang Shi said. "How I am, what my position in the Liang family is—none of that is important."

"How is it not important?" Liang Xinhe's eyes widened immediately. "You are the Third Miss of the Liang family, without a doubt."

"It's not important." Liang Shi still said. "What's important now is how you all conduct yourselves at home. Why do you think last night was big brother's fault? Big brother was already being very respectful—he held a welcome banquet, the whole family eating together."

Liang Shi stood from a very objective angle to evaluate last night's farce, trying to analyze it for Liang Xinhe.

"Dad doesn't really manage the company now, right? Big brother handles everything, big and small. Granted, you can help quite a bit, but for big brother, it's still just a drop in the bucket. You experienced big brother's workload today—how was it?" Liang Shi asked him.

Liang Xinhe: ".....Very tiring."

"Big brother is already this tired, and has anyone in the family ever been considerate of him?" Liang Shi asked. "Besides, hasn't he always had this personality since he was little? You all say he treats me especially well, but have you ever seen him smile at me?"

Liang Xinhe: ".....No."

"Well, there you go. He treats everyone the same." Liang Shi said coldly. "Aside from occasionally being able to smile at clients, he's never made exceptions for anyone. So why should she expect big brother to put on a smiling face for her the moment she comes back?"

As Liang Shi spoke, she started projecting her own feelings into it, and suddenly got a bit angry.

She even felt a bit angry looking at Liang Xinhe, who had been playing fence-sitter all along.

"Just talking about how the two of them went out of town for three days—wasn't big brother busy handling everything inside and out because of that?" Liang Shi's words carried a hint of interrogation and displeasure. "Never mind that no one is grateful for his hard work, but they still want him to put on a smile? Do they deserve it? Do they?"

Liang Shi asked twice in succession, making Liang Xinhe feel guilty.

It was only after a while that Liang Xinhe realized that this "do they deserve it" also included criticism of him.

Did he deserve it?

He didn't.

Footnotes:

¹ **"As if he had lost his parents" (如喪考妣):** A Chinese idiom describing someone who looks extremely grief-stricken or dejected, as if they had just lost their parents. It's often used sarcastically to describe someone overreacting to a situation.

² **"Fence-sitter" / "Playing with mud" (和稀泥):** A Chinese expression meaning to try to smooth things over without taking a clear stance, to be wishy-washy, or to try to please both sides in a conflict without addressing the actual issues. Literally translates to "mixing thin mud."

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Liang Xinhe slapped his forehead. After being told off by Liang Shi like this, he felt deeply regretful—he should have stood up to help big brother back then.

At the time, he hadn't realized there was any problem. He just thought big brother was making a mountain out of a molehill.

The atmosphere that had been relatively peaceful was suddenly torn apart.

And because of this, he got slapped.

All in all, that made two slaps now.

From childhood to adulthood, he had always been the child his parents were most proud of, a favored son of heaven¹—when had he ever suffered such grievances?

Liang Xinhe also felt upset about it.

But what he had thought at the time was, wouldn't everything be fine if big brother just admitted his mistake?

But after being told off by Liang Shi today, he felt like he was really worthless.

His ears turned red from embarrassment.

"Big brother works hard without complaint and has never complained about being tired despite giving so much, right? That bunch of people are enjoying the fruits of big brother's labor, yet they keep stirring up trouble, hitting him, it's just....."

Liang Shi's eyes reddened as she spoke, her voice slightly choked. "I don't understand you people."

Liang Xinhe: ".....I don't understand myself either."

Liang Shi let out a soft snort. "Then you better get busy now and experience big brother's life. See if you can still maintain big brother's temperament after you go home."

Liang Xinhe: "....."

"I'll call big brother right now and apologize on my knees, okay?" Liang Xinhe took out his phone. "I didn't realize last night."

"So basically whoever cries is right?" Liang Shi clicked her tongue. "Then have Ling Dang wail and cry when you go home tonight. It's just... it's so ridiculous!"

Liang Shi said this evaluation through gritted teeth, then got angrier as she spoke, so angry that she stood up directly. "I don't want to talk to you anymore."

Liang Xinhe: ".....?"

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When Liang Shi got off the elevator, she wanted to call Liang Xinzhou again, but her finger pressed on the screen and then she canceled it.

It was better to let him cool down.

But after Liang Shi returned to the magazine department and greeted each colleague, she sat down at her workstation and first sent Liang Xinzhou a text message.

[Big brother, you really don't need to worry about me. Zhuzi and I have already moved out, and I have money on hand. I'm joining the crew to film next week, and I'll be looking for an agent and assistant. The drama I'm going to film was introduced to me by Zhao Ying, and my relationship with Zhao Xuning is pretty good now too—the apartment is rented from her. You and sister-in-law should just treat this as taking a break outside. Don't think about those annoying company matters. Anyway, with second brother there, such a big company won't collapse in a day or two. You've been busy for so long, so give yourself a little vacation! Everyone needs to have a moment where they live for themselves. In this moment, you're not anyone's son, nor anyone's older brother—you're simply just you.]

After sending that, she also sent Liang Xinzhou a WeChat message.

[WeChat Red Packet²]

[Little sister is treating you and sister-in-law to milk tea! (PS: In this weather, putting on a jacket and buying two hot drinks to walk in the park is very comfortable! Don't buy milk tea for sister-in-law!³)]

[Oh right, congratulations to big brother and sister-in-law. Remind sister-in-law to take good care of the baby. Nothing else is important—she herself is the most important!]

Liang Shi had already learned from Liang Xinhe that sister-in-law was pregnant, and she was quite happy for Liang Xinzhou.

Among all the people in the Liang family she interacted with, she still liked big brother the most. There was an inherent sense of closeness.

As if she had met him many years ago.

Perhaps during the time she had previously come to this world, she had spent a long time with big brother.

Although Liang Xinzhou was strict, he was cold on the outside but warm on the inside.

Those who spent time with him would know.

Soon, the fifty-yuan red packet was claimed, and Liang Xinzhou sent her an OK gesture.

On the other end of the city, Yu Wan had just finished her afternoon nap and came downstairs. Seeing Liang Xinzhou sitting there playing with his phone, she asked him: "When did you wake up? Did you even sleep at all?"

Liang Xinzhou: "I slept for a bit."

He got up to help support Yu Wan. "Why didn't you sleep a little longer?"

"I've always been a light sleeper." Yu Wan said. "Being able to sleep now is already good enough. After such a big incident happened, I can still fall asleep—I admire the current me."

"It's a special situation." Liang Xinzhou's hand rested on her belly. "You don't need to worry about those things. I'll handle them."

"I believe you, but I just get angrier the more I think about it." Yu Wan patted his hand. "I never even asked you to smile at me—I couldn't even experience that when we were dating. How dare she?"

Liang Xinzhou: "....."

Liang Xinzhou forced a smile, but Yu Wan frowned in disdain. "Alright, you don't need to force yourself to do things you're not good at. You don't look as good smiling as you do with a cold face. I like the way you look with a cold face—it's sexy."

Liang Xinzhou: "....."

He even felt like the word "sexy" was an insult now.

But Yu Wan said to him: "Why are you looking at your phone again? How frustrating."

Liang Xinzhou replied: "Liang Shi sent me a message, so I was just checking it."

Yu Wan knew he had special feelings for this little sister, so she didn't say anything. She just asked him: "What did she send?"

Liang Xinzhou handed her the phone, his tone relaxed and proud: "Suddenly feel like she's grown up."

After Yu Wan read it, she was also somewhat moved. "I kind of understand why you like her the most in the family."

Being able to understand others' hard work and feel grateful, and encouraging people to do what they love.

This would make people feel deeply gratified.

It was a very pleasant intimate relationship.

Footnotes:

¹ **"Favored son of heaven" (天之驕子):** A Chinese idiom referring to someone who is extremely talented, lucky, or blessed—a person who seems to be favored by fate or the heavens. Often used to describe someone who has had a privileged or successful life.

² **WeChat Red Packet (微信紅包):** A digital monetary gift sent through WeChat, China's most popular messaging app. It's based on the traditional Chinese custom of giving red envelopes containing money during holidays and special occasions. Users can send specific amounts of money to individuals or groups.

³ **"Don't buy milk tea for sister-in-law!":** This is because pregnant women are typically advised to limit caffeine intake, and milk tea often contains tea (which has caffeine). Liang Shi is being thoughtful about her sister-in-law's pregnancy by suggesting hot drinks but reminding her brother to get something caffeine-free for his pregnant wife.

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Liang Xinzhou nodded: "I raised her, after all. When she was little, she was such a tiny thing. When she first learned to walk, she would toddle unsteadily, insisting on chasing after you. After she learned to walk properly, she would act cute and ask to be carried. When she saw sweat on your forehead, she would lift her sleeve to wipe it for you. After wiping, she would specifically say she wanted to get down and walk, because she felt bad that gege was tired."

Yu Wan looked at him. "Aren't you afraid I'll get jealous when you talk like that? She has no blood relation to you now."

"She's still my little sister." Liang Xinzhou smiled as he said this.

A very natural smile, genuine happiness from the heart. "So when I look at her now, it's like the her from when she was little has come back."

"Indeed." Yu Wan said. "When I first married into your family, I thought Liang Shi was the most annoying one. But if you really asked me what was annoying about her, it wasn't that bad—she was just lifeless, always with a gloomy face. Now she's... very sunny, and comfortable to be around. When I watch her play with Ling Dang, I even feel like joining in."

Liang Xinzhou held her hand. "Then let's go for a walk in the park this afternoon and use little sister's money to buy you some hot milk."

Yu Wan laughed softly. "Alright, Mr. Liang."

In this moment, Liang Xinzhou was just her husband, the father of the baby in her belly.

Not President Liang of Dongheng Group, not needing to worry about so many complicated matters.

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Liang Shi simply felt it was unfair for Liang Xinzhou. After sending that message, she felt much better inside.

In the afternoon, she handed over her work to her colleagues. She didn't have much on hand, so the handover was completed quickly.

After finishing, she just sat there waiting for everyone to get off work, playing with her phone out of boredom.

While scrolling through Weibo, she discovered a hashtag called #Qingyi University Woman in Red#.

Liang Shi: ".....?"

She clicked in with curiosity, then clicked out with embarrassment.

The hashtag was created by a marketing account, and the content following it read: This morning, a woman in red appeared on the field at Qingyi University. Her outstanding appearance attracted many onlookers. Many people asked for her contact information on the confession wall¹, but discovered she wasn't from Qingyi University. So a campaign was launched across the internet to find the #Qingyi University Woman in Red#, to see if netizens have the ability to do so.

Below were nine photos in a grid.

They were all candid shots taken by students.

Because the autumn wind was strong, the hem of the red dress was blown up by the wind—no need for a hair dryer.

The casual candid shots were all incredibly beautiful.

The comments below were all unanimous praise.

[I was lucky enough to see this jiejie² up close in the restroom. I can only say, she's really beautiful.]

[Not to the level of toppling nations and cities³, but enough to strike my heart.]

[These netizens are slacking—haven't found jiejie's Weibo yet?]

[I'm setting up camp in the comments section. As a face-con⁴, I've already fallen into jiejie's sea of love.]

[Starting today, I'm a fish in jiejie's pond. This is too bewitching—who could resist?]

[.....]

As it happened, Zhao Ling also saw the trending topic and asked her if she needed to make a clarification. After all, she was going to enter the entertainment industry, and mentioning her would help her gain a wave of followers.

Liang Shi sent over her Weibo account, which was just her name.

Zhao Ling immediately followed her.

But just as Zhao Ling was about to clarify, some resourceful netizens had already traced it back to Liang Shi.

[Friends, case solved! It's the third female lead jiejie from Mo Mo Mo Mo Mo Mo Mo Mo Mo Mo "Mo Mo Mo Mo Mo Mo Mo Mo Mo"!]

[Go look at the costume photos. Today, whose tears uncontrollably flowed down from the corner of their mouth? It's me.]

[I went to look. That red dress is still the most beautiful! I'm writing a blood petition⁵ begging the director to arrange scenes with the beauty wearing a red dress.]

[Seconding the above, 10086⁶.]

[.....]

Liang Shi's Weibo followers started growing at an extremely fast rate—to the point where her phone started lagging.

Every refresh added several hundred followers, every refresh added several hundred private messages. Red notification dots were everywhere—enough to drive someone with mild OCD crazy.

But it was also a sweet burden.

Taking advantage of this wave of popularity, Liang Shi posted a Weibo for work purposes, with photos of herself wearing JK⁷ and wearing the red dress.

Two photos total, with a very strong contrast.

@Liang Shi: Does this count as being able to pull off both cool and sweet? /picture/picture

The comments section was rapidly occupied by face-cons.

[How could it not count?!]

[Wuwuwu, can I really see this for free?]

[Jiejie, I have a friend who wants you to show that section of your waistline.]

[The person above, please put some clothes on!]

[.....]

Many people came to get close to the beauty, and the comment section's atmosphere completely changed.

Liang Shi's Weibo follower count surged—in less than half an hour, she already had over ten thousand followers.

Liang Shi secretly took a peek at Xu Qingzhu's Weibo and found that Xu Qingzhu had over 700,000 followers.

Ah... there really are so many face-cons in this world.

Liang Shi wasn't someone who was very addicted to social media, so after posting a Weibo and scanning through the comments section, she exited the app.

She read the script on her computer for a while. When it was almost five o'clock, Zhou Li and the others had a meeting.

Liang Shi glanced at the time and quietly asked Zhou Li: "Do you need me to pick up Rainbow for you?"

Zhou Li: "....."

She paused for a moment. "If you're not busy."

"I'm not busy." Liang Shi said. "After I pick her up, I'll take her directly to the place where we're having dinner tonight."

Zhou Li nodded: "Okay, thank you. I'll send you the restaurant address later. We'll try to finish up here as early as possible."

Liang Shi: "Sure thing."

After packing up everything at her workstation, looking at the empty space, Liang Shi felt a bit reluctant to leave.

She carried her cardboard box downstairs and encountered some familiar faces on the way. Although she couldn't recall their names, she knew which department they were from.

Before she knew it, she had already spent nearly a month with everyone.

But no matter how reluctant she was, she had to say goodbye.

This was the first place where Liang Shi was recognized after she arrived.

Footnotes:

¹ **Confession wall (表白牆)**: A popular feature on Chinese university social media platforms or bulletin boards where students can anonymously post confessions of love, search for people they've seen on campus, or share messages. It's similar to a "missed connections" board.

² **Jiejie (姐姐)**: Chinese term for "older sister," but commonly used as a respectful and affectionate way to address an older woman or a woman one admires.

³ **"Toppling nations and cities" (傾國傾城)**: A classical Chinese idiom used to describe someone of extraordinary beauty—so beautiful that they could cause the downfall of nations and cities. It originates from ancient Chinese literature.

⁴ **Face-con (顏狗)**: Literally "face dog," Chinese internet slang for someone who is attracted to or appreciates beautiful faces; a person who judges or likes others based on their appearance. Similar to the term "visual stan."

⁵ **Blood petition (血書)**: A dramatic way of expressing extreme sincerity or desperation in a request, referencing the historical practice of writing petitions in one's own blood to show devotion. Used humorously online to express strong wishes.

⁶ **10086**: The customer service number for China Mobile. Used as internet slang to mean "I strongly agree" or "I support this," as if saying "I'll call customer service to complain if this doesn't happen."

⁷ **JK**: Short for "Joshi Kosei" (女子高生), meaning Japanese high school girl. In this context, it refers to Japanese high school girl-style uniforms, which have become a popular fashion subculture in China.

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When Liang Shi drove to the entrance of Rainbow's kindergarten, it was right at dismissal time. Cars could no longer get in, so she could only park a bit farther away.

She got out of the car and walked toward the kindergarten entrance. Standing among the group of moms, she felt out of place.

Though the other moms probably didn't feel that way.

She also saw Sun Meirou at the school entrance, there to pick up Ling Dang.

The two stood there chatting for a while. Sun Meirou looked worried, so Liang Shi comforted her with a few words.

Sun Meirou smiled helplessly: "Why are you comforting me? You're the one having the hardest time right now. Where are you living now? If you don't have a place, Xinhe bought one before—you can move in there first."

Liang Xinhe wasn't as wealthy as Liang Xinzhou, who had bought three to five properties outside.

Liang Xinhe had a child to raise at home, didn't have much authority in the company, and spent money extravagantly. He used to give Liang Shi hundreds of thousands in pocket money and basically hadn't saved any money at all.

He had only bought one property, probably kept for emergencies.

After all, Liang Xinhe probably never thought he would move out of the old residence.

Liang Shi declined: "Second sister-in-law, no need. I have a place to stay."

"Do you still have money?" Sun Meirou asked. "I have some here too. Don't think it's too little."

As she spoke, she handed over a bank card. "It's what I saved before. It can help you in an emergency."

"I'm really not in need." Liang Shi said helplessly, pushing the card back to her. "Keep it to buy things for Ling Dang. I have money on hand."

Sun Meirou looked troubled and could only sigh helplessly.

But Liang Shi said to her: "Ling Dang is a child. She's always been the only one at home, so she's used to speaking without a filter. Plus, she's at the age where she likes to imitate what people say. Be more careful at home. About what happened last night....."

Sun Meirou frowned, also looking quite troubled.

"You still need to protect the child's innocence." Liang Shi said. "It's hard on you, second sister-in-law."

"I know." Sun Meirou said. "I don't have any objections to that new little sister, but what Ling Dang said last night—she's probably holding a grudge now. Mother-in-law listens to everything she says now, afraid we might make her feel wronged. To be honest with you, I've been walking on eggshells all day."

Liang Shi lowered her eyes and suggested quietly: "Have you thought about moving out?"

"I brought it up last night—let's just move out like big brother did." Sun Meirou said. "But your second brother said that big brother moving out already made Mom so angry she got sick. If we move out too....."

Sun Meirou shook her head helplessly. "Forget it. I'll just endure it. As long as I protect Ling Dang, it'll be fine. No matter how bad she is, she wouldn't go after a child."

Liang Shi respected her decision and only reminded her to make sure Ling Dang doesn't run wild like before.

When Ling Dang came out, she circled around Liang Shi, pitifully complaining that she didn't like the new auntie and wanted to go home with Liang Shi that night.

But Liang Shi persuaded her to go back. It was already a sensitive period—the Liang Xinzhou couple had just moved out. If Ling Dang didn't go home at night either, it would probably trigger another round of arguments.

Although Liang Shi also kind of wanted to anger Qiu Zimin, using a child wasn't right.

Ling Dang dejectedly followed Sun Meirou away.

By the time she picked up Rainbow, it was getting late. Dusk was falling, and the streetlights around them lit up all at once, casting the autumn scenery in a dim, beautiful glow.

Liang Shi held Rainbow's hand and walked toward the car. When they were almost there, she saw Qi Jiao walking out. After a moment's thought, she handed the car keys to Rainbow, telling her to go wait in the car while she took care of something.

Rainbow first pressed the unlock button to confirm which car it was, then looked up and asked her: "Are you going to find Teacher Qi again?"

Liang Shi nodded.

Rainbow tugged at her backpack straps as she walked, not forgetting to say: "You look for Teacher Qi every time you come. Won't Sister Xu really get angry?"

Liang Shi was startled: "Why would she get angry?"

Rainbow stopped in her tracks and looked at her with an expression of disappointment¹: "Teacher Qi is also a pretty girl, you know."

Liang Shi: "....."

Rainbow said earnestly: "Jiejie Liang, doing this will make Sister Xu jealous."

Liang Shi: "....."

She said helplessly: "Don't worry about adults' relationship problems."

Rainbow pouted and went to wait in the car.

Liang Shi quickly walked over to find Qi Jiao. Qi Jiao also caught sight of her from the corner of her eye and walked even faster, but Liang Shi still caught up to her.

"Teacher Qi." Liang Shi stood with her by the roadside. "Why are you running?"

Qi Jiao clutched the strap of her canvas bag and asked in return: "Why are you chasing?"

Liang Shi: "I want to ask you about something."

Qi Jiao pressed her lips together: "I have nothing to say."

She was dressed the same as before—a light yellow long dress with a cardigan over it, her hair in a half ponytail with the rest draped softly over her shoulders, and a light purple hair tie on her head.

She looked gentle and serene.

Liang Shi suddenly thought of that little girl nestled beside Gu Zhaoyuan.

After seeing her teenage photos and then looking at her now, she seemed to have been prettier before.

Now there were traces of artificiality, though you couldn't tell at all unless you looked closely.

Footnotes:

¹ **"Looked at her with an expression of disappointment"** (恨鐵不成鋼): A Chinese idiom that literally means "hating iron for not becoming steel." It describes the feeling of frustration or disappointment when someone you care about fails to meet expectations or doesn't live up to their potential. Here, Rainbow is using this expression humorously, acting like a disappointed elder toward Liang Shi's romantic obliviousness.

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Liang Shi said: "I'll only take up a little bit of your time."

Qi Jiao still shook her head: "What you mentioned before—I don't want to do it. Don't come looking for me anymore. There won't be any results."

After saying this, she turned to leave, but Liang Shi suddenly lowered her voice and said: "What about Gu Zhaoyuan then?"

Qi Jiao suddenly stopped in her tracks and turned to look at her. She opened her mouth to say something but pressed her lips together instead. Tears glistened in her eyes. She clenched her fists tightly, then released them.

She gritted her teeth to suppress her sadness, and when she looked at Liang Shi, her voice was cold and hard: "What are you talking about? I don't understand."

"What about Gu Yingbo then?" Liang Shi continued. "He's currently in a half-mad, half-foolish state. Does that also have nothing to do with you?"

"What?" Qi Jiao's eyes widened instantly. "Why would he go mad?"

Tears fell from Qi Jiao's eyes. "You're lying to me, aren't you? Are you trying to trick me?"

"No." Liang Shi called her by her original name in a low voice. "Gu Xingyue, I wish I were tricking you, but this is all true."

"You....." Qi Jiao was stunned. She pulled Liang Shi to the side of the road and looked up to ask her: "How exactly did you find out?"

"Part guessing, part logical deduction." Liang Shi said. "I just happened to discover it. Although I don't know what conditions Yang Jiani promised you, I know that Dean Gu going mad is related to you. You've endured all these years without going to see Dean Gu and Gu Zhaoyuan because you were afraid of implicating them, right? Yang Jiani must have used them to threaten you, right? So does Yang Jiani have some leverage over Dean Gu? To the point that you had to suffer so much. And we deduced that Dean Gu became this way out of guilt after witnessing you being abused by Yang Jiani."

Gu Xingyue clenched her fists tightly. "What... what do you mean by this?"

Her mouth was slightly open, her face full of disbelief.

Seeing her in this state, Liang Shi could only briefly tell her what she knew, then let her consider whether what she was doing now was worth it.

After thinking, Gu Xingyue still wanted to refuse, but when the words reached her lips, she couldn't say them.

She could only say in a trembling voice: "Let me think about it."

Liang Shi nodded: "I'll give you enough time. Don't worry—if anything happens with Dean Gu, I'll notify you immediately. Don't act any differently at the Qi family either, so you won't... get hurt again."

Hearing this, a trace of confusion flashed in Gu Xingyue's eyes. "Why are you being so good to me?"

Liang Shi smiled gently. "Because an older sister should protect her younger sister."

After saying this subconsciously, even Liang Shi was startled.

Why... did she say that?

It was as if someone had once said this to her.

After all, given the current situation, Gu Xingyue was actually older than her.

Gu Xingyue was also confused, so Liang Shi explained: "Qi Jiao-jiejie¹ once said this to me, so I want to seek justice for her death."

//

Liang Shi took Rainbow to the gathering place, and the whole way there, she still couldn't figure out why she had said those words.

In the end, she could only attribute it to Qi Jiao having once said this to her.

The Qi Jiao she saw in her dreams was too warm—a sun that carried its own light source even while in darkness.

Liang Shi thought that she must have received a lot of protection from her when she was little, which was why she didn't want her to die without clarity now.

The person was clearly already dead, yet there was another person taking her place.

At the evening gathering, Liang Shi was the main character, so everyone kept pushing her to drink.

She didn't refuse anyone, and soon she had drunk a bit too much. She couldn't even hold on for a second round, and everyone laughed at her poor alcohol tolerance.

After drinking too much, Liang Shi didn't have those bad habits of being stubborn or trying to act tough. She just sat there gently, smiling serenely. "Yeah, I thought I could really hold my liquor."

This made everyone burst into laughter, all saying she was acting cute and begging for mercy.

Hearing this, Liang Shi frowned and shook her head. "I'm not acting cute. At most, it counts as begging for mercy."

They partied until after nine, and it was almost time to disperse. Everyone had drunk quite a bit and pulled Liang Shi aside to speak from the heart.

For example, when she first arrived at the company, they really couldn't stand her, but after getting to know her, they felt that Xiao Liang² was really nice—sitting in the office, she was a beautiful sight.

Liang Shi said to everyone: "Then let's all keep in touch."

"Come on, you're going to be a big star in the future." Everyone said. "How are we supposed to keep in touch?"

"Even as a big star, I'm still Xiao Liang." Liang Shi said modestly.

Those who had cars basically all called for designated drivers³. Just as Li Ran was about to call a designated driver for Liang Shi, Liang Shi's phone rang.

Li Ran swiped to answer for Liang Shi and held it up to her ear.

The tipsy Liang Shi answered groggily: "Hello?"

Xu Qingzhu could tell from her voice. "Had too much to drink?"

"Who's this?" Liang Shi asked.

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

She announced herself coldly: "Xu Qingzhu."

Liang Shi's brain froze for a few seconds, then she broke into a deeply satisfied smile. Her voice lowered, carrying a faintly flirtatious undertone: "Oh, it's my wife~"

Footnotes:

¹ **Jiejie (姐姐)**: Chinese term for "older sister." Liang Shi is referring to Qi Jiao (the real one who died) as an older sister figure.

² **Xiao Liang (小梁)**: "Xiao" (小) meaning "little" or "young" is a common prefix added to surnames in Chinese as an affectionate or casual way to address someone, especially a younger colleague or friend. So "Xiao Liang" is an endearing way to call Liang Shi.

³ **Designated driver (代駕)**: In China, there are professional designated driver services where you can hire someone to drive your car home for you if you've been drinking. This is different from the Western concept of having a friend be the designated driver—it's a paid service where someone comes to wherever you are and drives your own car for you.